

Festivals

Throughout the Hindu year, festivals celebrate the gods in a variety of ways. At Janmashtami, Hindus commemorate Krishna's birthday with readings of the *Bhagavad-Gita* and gifts of sweets. Divali, the festival of lights, remembers the story of lord Rama's victory over his enemies and his lamp-lit procession home.

Pilgrims come to bathe in the River Ganges.

The sacred water is said to wash away one's sins.

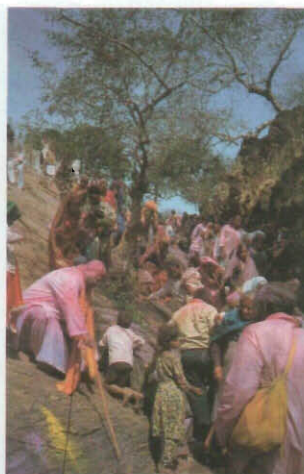


Holi

The festival of Holi is held for two days in spring to celebrate the rescue of Krishna from the clutches of the demoness Holika, who was burnt to death by Vishnu. After worship a bonfire is lit to symbolise good overcoming evil. Dancing and processions take place.

Pilgrimages

Going on a pilgrimage to a holy place is important for many Hindus. They may go to a shrine or to a place where one of the gods is said to have appeared on Earth, believing that their prayers are more likely to be answered if said at such a place. A favourite goal for pilgrimage is a holy river, particularly the River Ganges, in north-western India. Varanasi on the Ganges is India's most sacred city.

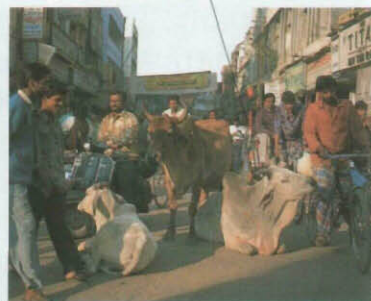


On the second day of Holi, people of all castes cover each other with coloured powders.

Sacred cows

The white cow is a Hindu symbol of the soul, and cows are sacred in Hinduism. They are allowed to rove freely, and there are penalties for killing a cow. Hindus may drink milk and use cow dung as fuel, but must not kill cows for food. The cow's status is part of a wider respect for life and many Hindus are vegetarians.

Daily traffic in the city of Delhi skirts around seated cows.



Worship

Since Hindus believe that god is in everything, any human activity, done well, can become an act of worship. But Hindus also perform special acts of worship at least once a day. They may worship in a temple, but the most common place for worship is in the home, in front of a shrine to a favourite god. Rituals include meditation and reciting sacred texts and prayers. Hindus light candles, make offerings to the gods, and waft incense around the shrine.



Vishnu is the main image.

Krishna and his half-brother Balarama are shown with Vishnu.

Shrines

The household shrine is the focus of daily worship. It may contain an image of one of the principal gods, plus pictures of other deities. It may also have a container full of water from the sacred River Ganges. Although some shrines are elaborately decorated, others may be as simple as a shelf or holy picture in the corner of a room.

Shesha the serpent protects Vishnu.

Puja

Before puja (worship) takes place, the image of the god is washed, dried, and anointed with turmeric or sandalwood powder. Offerings such as flowers, fruit, and cooked food are made to the god. The worshipper stands or sits in front of the shrine, reciting holy texts.



Incense burner

Burning incense welcomes the god to his shrine.

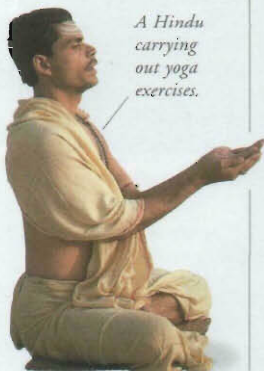
Kamal

This scent-shaker is shaped like the lotus flower, the symbol of creation.

Yoga

All Hindus strive to break the cycle of rebirth (samsara) and merge with Brahman. They believe that one way of achieving this state is through following the physical and mental disciplines of yoga. There are different types of yoga, but all aim to attain ultimate spiritual enlightenment.

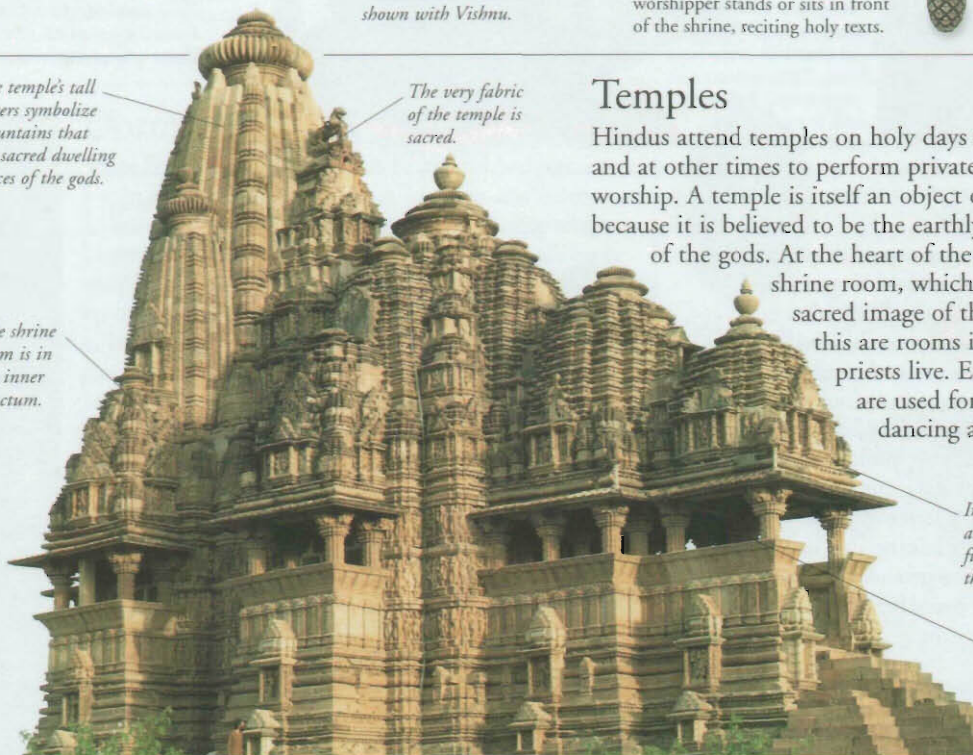
A Hindu carrying out yoga exercises.



The temple's tall towers symbolize mountains that are sacred dwelling places of the gods.

The very fabric of the temple is sacred.

The shrine room is in the inner sanctum.



Images of gods and mythological figures may adorn the temple walls.

Windows represent the ears of the divine body.

Temples

Hindus attend temples on holy days and festivals, and at other times to perform private acts of worship. A temple is itself an object of worship because it is believed to be the earthly dwelling place of the gods. At the heart of the temple is the shrine room, which contains the sacred image of the god. Around this are rooms in which the priests live. Entrance halls are used for religious dancing and music.

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